Clothing Category Recognition with Pixels and HOG

Phase 1: Classical Machine Learning

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***Abstract*—We compare normalized pixel intensities and Histogram of Oriented Gradients (HOG) for ten-class clothing recognition using Logistic Regression, k nearest neighbors, Random Forest and an RBF Support Vector Machine. Fashion-MNIST's official training partition supplies a seeded 48,000/12,000 fit/validation split; the official 10,000-image test partition remains separate. A small development search uses a shared 12,000-example fit subset, after which all eight final pipelines are fitted on the same 48,000 examples. The validation-selected HOG + RBF SVM obtains 90.91% test accuracy and 0.9090 macro F1. Its weakest category recall is Shirt at 73.30%. We report all ten class recalls, paired error examples, inference timing and model-specific storage measures. The findings concern the declared benchmark pipelines and do not establish a CNN result or real-catalogue deployment performance.**

***Index Terms*—Fashion-MNIST, HOG, classical classification, validation, error analysis**

I. Introduction

Automatic category tags can help organize a small clothing inventory. An image classifier maps an input picture to a category label, but visually similar garments make aggregate accuracy an incomplete description of usefulness. This project asks whether a fixed local-edge descriptor changes recognition relative to raw intensities and whether the effect depends on the classifier.

The Phase 1 contribution is a controlled two-representation by four-classifier comparison with traceable predictions, explicit validation selection and class-specific error analysis. It is an empirical course baseline, not a new learning algorithm. The broader project title includes a small CNN, but CNN training and the classical-versus-CNN comparison are reserved for Phase 2.

II. Related Work

Fashion-MNIST provides a compact public benchmark for visual classification and motivates a reproducible comparison on shared labeled images [1]. Dataset benchmark scores are contextual evidence, not this team's results or guaranteed targets.

Dalal and Triggs study HOG for human detection using locally normalized edge histograms [2]. Their task differs from clothing-category classification, so we adapt the descriptor settings without transferring their performance claims. Breiman's randomized-tree ensemble formulation provides a contrasting model family [3]. The support-vector formulation motivates margin-based classification [4]; our RBF, multiclass implementation follows the documented software rather than reproducing that paper's experiments.

The scikit-learn implementation supplies consistent fit/predict interfaces [5], while scikit-image documents the HOG extraction used here [6]. LeCun et al. provide background for later learned spatial representations [7]. That direction remains a Phase 2 hypothesis, with no CNN outcome inferred from Phase 1.

III. Data Quality and Exploration

The official data contain 28×28 grayscale images in ten clothing categories. We preserve the official 60,000-example training and 10,000-example test partitions. Raw files are downloaded from the official repository and verified against its published MD5 content checksums. Integer category IDs remain intact and original row IDs identify every prediction.

Only official training data are used for exploratory choices. Executed checks confirm uint8 pixels in the range 0–255, finite values, one label per image, all ten labels, no all-zero images and no exact duplicate image groups. Consequently, there are no exact fit/validation duplicate groups or conflicting labels within exact-image groups in the training audit. Hash equality does not detect all near-duplicates or establish semantic label correctness. No examples are removed or relabeled.

A stratified random split with seed 42 yields 48,000 fit and 12,000 validation examples, with 4,800 and 1,200 examples per category respectively. Saved indices and file hashes prevent teammates from silently using different membership. Figure 1 shows the class balance. Seeded galleries and mean images, retained with the notebook, help check orientation and appearance variation. Similar silhouettes motivate, but do not predetermine, the later shirt/T-shirt/pullover error analysis.

IV. Features and Models

A. Fixed Image Representations

Both paths accept upright raw uint8 images and divide intensities by 255 once. The pixel path flattens the grid into 784 ordered values. This preserves values and recoverable positions but supplies no built-in neighborhood or translation structure to a conventional classifier.

HOG uses 9 orientation bins, 4×4-pixel cells, 2×2-cell blocks and L2-Hys normalization, with no square-root transform. Seven cells per axis yield six overlapping blocks per axis, hence

$$d_{HOG} = 6 \cdot 6 \cdot 2 \cdot 2 \cdot 9 = 1296. \quad (1)$$

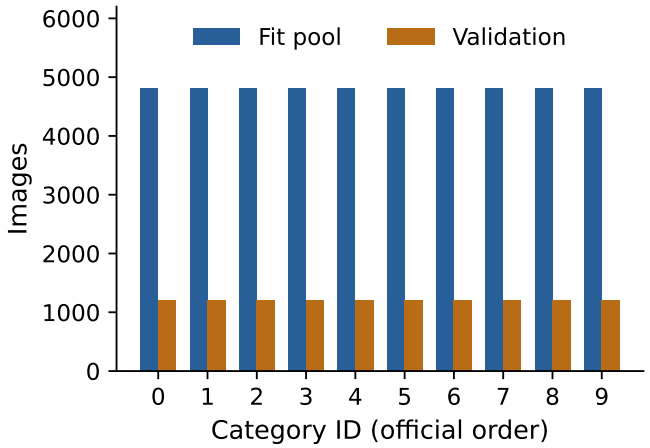


Fig. 1. Class counts in the saved split of official training data. Both pools are balanced. These are data checks rather than performance measurements.

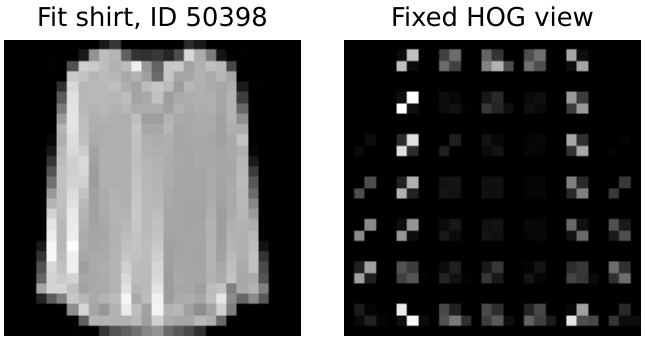


Fig. 2. A fit-partition shirt and its HOG visualization. The visualization illustrates a fixed descriptor, not learned classifier attention.

HOG is therefore a structural representation rather than dimensionality reduction in this configuration. Its extraction rule is fixed before label-based training. Figure 2 illustrates its edge-direction view.

StandardScaler is learned inside training Pipelines for Logistic Regression, SVM and HOG kNN. Pixel kNN and both forest variants use the fixed features directly. This declared, model-specific choice makes the comparison one of complete pipelines. Fixed per-image extraction may be cached; learned means and scales must be fitted only on the fit partition [8].

B. Logistic Regression

Class scores are $z_c = w_c^T x + b_c$ and softmax gives $p(c|x) = \exp(z_c)/\sum_j \exp(z_j)$. Multiclass cross-entropy with regularization learns the coefficients. Smaller C means stronger regularization. We use LBFGS with at most 2,000 iterations and validate $C \in \{0.1, 1\}$. This is linear in the supplied representation and need not exploit the same information from pixels and HOG.

C. k Nearest Neighbors

kNN stores the fit feature vectors and predicts from a distance-weighted vote among the nearest examples under Euclidean distance. We validate $k \in \{3, 5\}$ with brute-force search. A small fit time is not a low total-compute guarantee: neighbor search and stored training data make inference and memory important.

D. Random Forest

We combine 200 bootstrap-trained trees, with square-root feature sampling and minimum leaf size 1. Gini impurity is $1 - \sum_c p_c^2$. Randomization diversifies trees; depth controls each tree's flexibility. The implementation averages tree class probabilities. We validate depth 20 versus unrestricted depth, keeping random seed 42. Tree counts and nodes describe structure, rather than a directly comparable linear-model parameter count.

E. RBF Support Vector Machine

The kernel is $K(x, x') = \exp(-\gamma\|x - x'\|^2)$. C controls the violation penalty and γ the locality of similarity. SVC uses pairwise classifiers for the ten classes. We validate $C \in \{1, 10\}$ and hold `gamma='scale'` fixed. Probability estimation is disabled because the requested metrics need predicted labels. A recorded version-1.9 deprecation warning concerns that explicit probability option; it is not a convergence failure. Kernel fitting and support-vector prediction can be costly.

V. Experimental Protocol

A. Development and Final Fitting

The compact search has two candidates for each of eight representation/model rows, or 16 development fits. Every candidate sees the same stratified 12,000 fit-pool examples and unchanged 12,000 validation examples. A separate 2,000/1,000 smoke path checks the interfaces and cannot unlock final testing.

Within each row, the development candidate with the highest validation macro F1 is selected, with accuracy, lower validation prediction time and run ID as tie-breakers. All eight selected configurations are then fitted afresh on the full 48,000 fit examples. This is not a fit on training plus validation. The overall model is selected from the eight full-profile validation results using the same rule. Its ID, all model hashes, settings, split hash and scores are frozen before loading official test content. Unconverged or failed runs cannot be selected. Search logs, including the recorded API warning, remain available.

All final models use identical fit, validation and test IDs. The test results describe the eight frozen finalists and do not trigger a new selection or hyperparameter change. The repository stores raw predictions in compressed CSV files, checks their IDs and true labels, and regenerates metrics in the executed master notebook.

TABLE I
OFFICIAL TEST RESULTS; ALL ROWS FIT ON THE SAME 48,000 IMAGES. * MARKS THE OVERALL VALIDATION-SELECTED MODEL. FIT TIME IS IN SECONDS.

Feature	Model	Acc. (%)	Macro F1	Fit (s)
Pixels	LR	84.01	0.8394	6.9
Pixels	kNN	85.04	0.8505	0.0
Pixels	RF	87.67	0.8753	57.5
Pixels	RBF SVM	89.28	0.8924	100.7
HOG	LR	87.60	0.8757	4.2
HOG	kNN	87.34	0.8730	0.2
HOG	RF	87.29	0.8718	104.9
HOG	RBF SVM*	90.91	0.9090	125.4

B. Metrics and Timing

Accuracy is the correct fraction. For category c,

$$R_c = \frac{TP_c}{TP_c + FN_c}, \qquad F1_c = \frac{2TP_c}{2TP_c + FP_c + FN_c}. \quad (2)$$

Macro F1 is $\frac{1}{10}\sum_c F1_c$, with labels 0–9 explicitly included and undefined precision/F1 set to zero. Per-class support accompanies recall. Rows of a confusion matrix are true classes; row-normalized diagonals equal recall.

Fit time includes scaler and classifier fitting but excludes fixed feature extraction and the development search. Inference uses already loaded models and 1,024 fixed test images in batches of 128, one warmup and five repeats under one native thread. Pipeline timing starts at cached fixed features. End-to-end timing includes raw-image normalization, pixel/HOG extraction, scaler and classifier, excluding disk reads and model loading. We report median amortized milliseconds per image, not single-request latency.

The recorded environment uses Python 3.12, scikit-learn 1.9.1 and scikit-image 0.26.0 on an Apple ARM64 macOS machine with 16 GiB RAM. Exact package versions and repeat durations are retained. Absolute timing depends on hardware, software and concurrent system load.

VI. Results and Error Analysis

A. Aggregate and Class-Specific Results

Table I reports the eight full-size final rows. The model selected before test evaluation, HOG + RBF SVM, reaches 90.91% accuracy and 0.9090 macro F1 on official test data. Figure 3 compares the fixed pipelines within classifier families. The separate most-frequent dummy is a validation reference, not one of the four required model families.

The observed HOG-minus-pixel macro-F1 changes, in percentage points, are LR: +3.63, kNN: +2.26, RF: -0.35, RBF SVM: +1.65. The direction and magnitude should be read within each family, with the fixed preprocessing and limited tuning budget in mind. These differences are not claims of statistical significance. Table II preserves all ten class recalls instead of hiding weak categories behind aggregate scores. The validation-selected model's weakest category is Shirt with 73.30% recall.

B. Observed Confusions and Paired Examples

For the selected model, the three largest off-diagonal counts are T-shirt/top predicted as Shirt (104 examples); Shirt predicted as T-shirt/top (103 examples); Shirt predicted as Coat (64 examples). Figure 4 focuses on four garment categories; the complete ten-by-ten count and normalized matrices remain in the notebook and figure directory. Shared outlines at low resolution are plausible sources of ambiguity, but the observed mistakes alone do not prove their cause or that the official labels are wrong.

We align pixel and HOG predictions on identical original IDs within each classifier, divide images into both-correct, pixels-only-correct, HOG-only-correct and both-wrong groups, and display the first original IDs in each group. This rule prevents selectively showing only favorable HOG examples. Figure 5 presents a subset for SVM; complete symmetric panels and group counts are retained. These post-freeze test examples are descriptive and were not used to modify the model.

C. Inference and Model Storage

Table III shows median amortized inference costs and compressed bundle storage under the same serialization policy. The selected pipeline's end-to-end measurement is 21.7090 ms per image. HOG extraction can change the deployment trade-off even when a classifier predicts quickly. Search time, training time, model loading and live single-image latency answer different questions and should not be substituted for this measurement.

Table IV uses W for learned classifier coefficients plus intercepts, X for stored kNN training-feature scalars, N for total forest nodes, and S for SVC support-vector, dual-coefficient and intercept array scalars. kNN has no learned coefficient count; this is recorded as not applicable rather than computationally free. Scaler mean/scale counts are stored separately. Storage also depends on data type, compression and implementation details.

VII. Limitations and Phase 2 Plan

The results use a single fixed split, one seed, two candidates per row and one HOG configuration. They do not establish globally optimal hyperparameters, statistically significant differences, or robustness to domain shift. The benchmark excludes much of the variation in production catalogue photographs. Exact duplicate checks are narrower than a semantic or near-duplicate audit. The representation comparison includes the disclosed scaler policy.

In Phase 2, a small two- or three-block CNN can test whether task-learned local features improve the remaining category confusions. That experiment should reuse the saved fit/validation/test membership, select architecture and early stopping using training-derived validation data, and compare accuracy, macro F1, recall and documented inference cost fairly. Since Phase 1 already reveals test outcomes, architecture choices must not be tuned to those outcomes. Any claimed

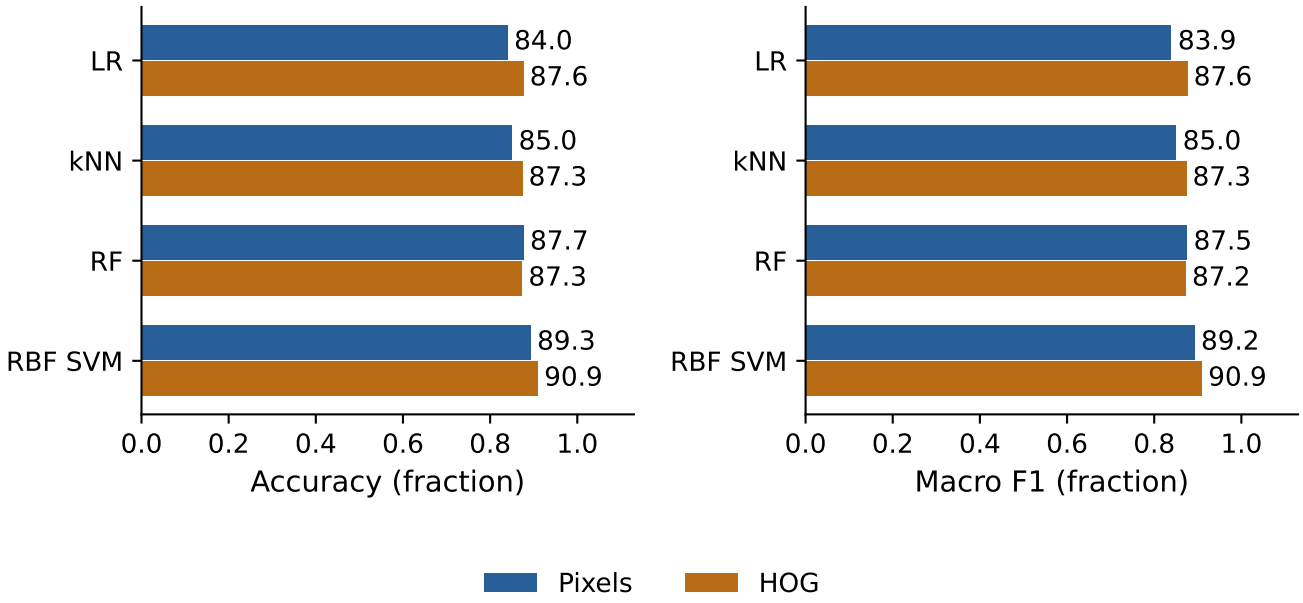


Fig. 3. Pixels versus HOG within each frozen classifier. The comparison changes the declared representation pipeline; it is not evidence that every possible HOG/scaler configuration dominates every pixel configuration.

TABLE II
TEST RECALL IN PERCENT FOR EVERY CLASS; EACH CATEGORY HAS 1,000 ACTUAL TEST IMAGES. T/TOP MEANS T-SHIRT/TOP AND BOOT MEANS ANKLE BOOT.

Pipeline	T/top	Trouser	Pullover	Dress	Coat	Sandal	Shirt	Sneaker	Bag	Boot
Pixels + LR	81.1	95.6	73.0	85.8	75.2	92.5	57.2	93.0	92.5	94.2
Pixels + kNN	83.9	96.8	79.7	85.7	76.1	80.4	60.1	95.7	95.1	96.9
Pixels + RF	85.7	95.7	80.1	90.6	82.3	95.5	59.4	95.0	97.5	94.9
Pixels + RBF SVM	84.4	97.3	82.9	89.9	82.2	96.2	69.6	96.6	97.8	95.9
HOG + LR	83.3	97.5	79.7	87.0	81.8	95.0	66.0	94.2	97.1	94.4
HOG + kNN	83.5	97.5	82.3	86.6	81.6	89.0	63.7	98.1	95.4	95.7
HOG + RF	85.1	94.8	81.2	89.4	82.2	94.8	60.2	93.7	96.8	94.7
HOG + RBF SVM	85.7	97.6	86.2	91.2	86.4	96.5	73.3	97.3	98.3	96.6

TABLE III
INFERENCE MILLISECONDS PER IMAGE, BATCH-AMORTIZED. STORAGE INCLUDES THE COMPRESSED MODEL BUNDLE AND METADATA, IN MIB.

Pipeline	Predict	End to end	MiB
Pixels + LR	0.0011	0.0014	0.05
Pixels + kNN	0.3291	0.3298	31.10
Pixels + RF	0.0758	0.0609	35.01
Pixels + RBF SVM	3.2622	3.2468	39.34
HOG + LR	0.0014	0.1473	0.08
HOG + kNN	0.8365	0.9880	147.27
HOG + RF	0.0574	0.2061	40.24
HOG + RBF SVM	21.3993	21.7090	87.82

TABLE IV
MODEL-SPECIFIC COMPLEXITY EVIDENCE. QUANTITIES HAVE DIFFERENT MEANINGS AND ARE NOT DIRECTLY INTERCHANGEABLE PARAMETER COUNTS.

Pipeline	Type	Count
Pixels + LR	W	7,850
Pixels + kNN	X	37,632,000
Pixels + RF	N	1,633,648
Pixels + RBF SVM	S	13,725,289
HOG + LR	W	12,970
HOG + kNN	X	62,208,000
HOG + RF	N	1,828,070
HOG + RBF SVM	S	27,295,425

hybrid method requires a meaningful technical rationale and its own evidence; no hybrid improvement is claimed here.

VIII. REPRODUCIBILITY AND CONTRIBUTIONS

The repository at https://github.com/Nakul-Jaglan/aml-dl-t089 contains source modules, meaningful integrity tests, saved split IDs, checksums, validation candidate logs, a hashed freeze manifest, ID-aligned predictions, metrics, figures and an executed master notebook. A fresh reproduction writes to an isolated output directory so checked-in frozen evidence stays intact. Large trained bundles, raw downloads

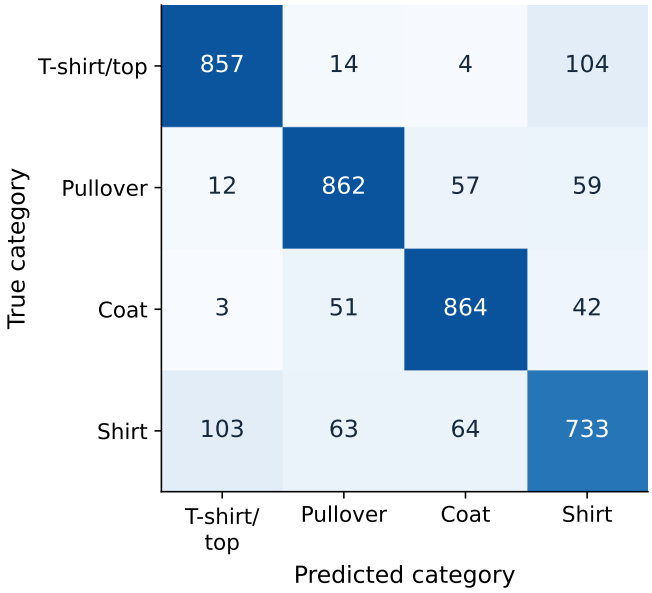


Fig. 4. Selected model's test counts for true/predicted T-shirt/top, Pullover, Coat and Shirt. This is a submatrix, so omitted-category errors are not shown and displayed rows need not total 1,000. Full matrices are retained separately.

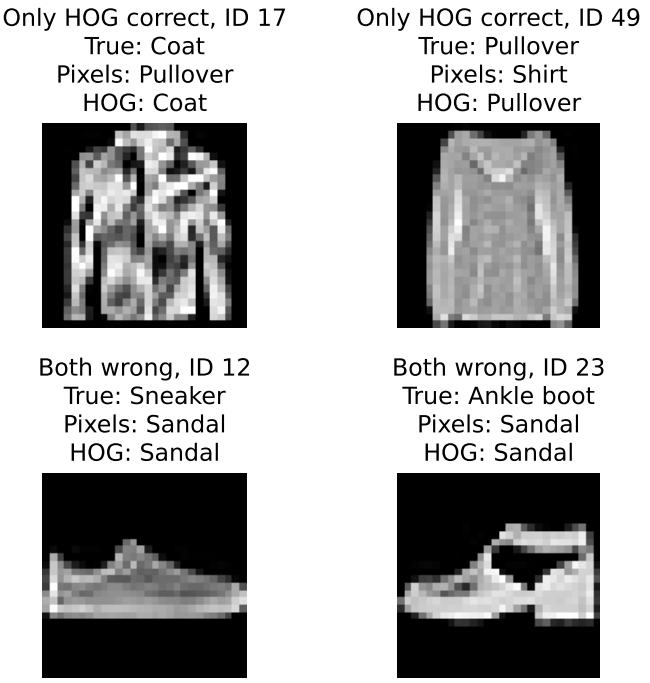


Fig. 5. Paired RBF SVM examples. Each displayed row uses the first two original test IDs in its outcome group. Additional pixels-only-correct and both-correct examples are saved with the complete error-analysis artifacts.

and feature caches are regenerated locally instead of committed to Git.

These initial artifacts were generated with AI assistance at Nakul's request. Planned ownership assigns Nakul integration/research/report assembly, Sudeshhna data/EDA, Puneet features/LR/kNN, Samarth RF/SVM/experiments and Neelanshu evaluation/error analysis. These plans do not assert completed independent work. Each member must review the relevant implementation, record actual changes or verification, and demonstrate whole-project understanding in the individual viva. Section A is confirmed. Student identifiers are included only in the private submission copy; institutional affiliation details and any faculty-specific template requirements still require team confirmation.

IX. Conclusion

The controlled Phase 1 experiment compares eight classical pipelines under shared data membership and validation-only model selection. The selected HOG + RBF SVM achieves 90.91% official-test accuracy and 0.9090 macro F1. Per-class recalls, paired errors and measured compute costs qualify the aggregate result. HOG's contribution is empirical and classifier-dependent under the declared preprocessing policy. Learned spatial features remain a concrete question for Phase 2 rather than a result asserted in advance.

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[8] scikit-learn developers, "Common pitfalls and recommended practices," https://scikit-learn.org/stable/common_pitfalls.html, 2026, accessed 27 October 2026; training-only preprocessing and pipelines.